CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

26/11: ‘A LIFE-CHANGING MOMENT’

A Symbol of Resilience

‘Mumbai is a symbol of the incredible energy and optimism that defines India in the twenty-first century. And ever since those horrific days [of the 26/11 attacks] … the Taj has been the symbol of the strength and the resilience of the Indian people,’ said US President Barack Obama on 6 November 2010 at the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel in Mumbai, twenty days before the second anniversary of the terrorist attack on the city in 2008. On that day, a group of armed terrorists from Pakistan had slipped into Mumbai and gone on a killing spree in various locations in the city, including the Taj and the Oberoi-Trident hotels. The series of attacks killed 166 people and left over 238 injured.

But in less than twenty-one months of the attack, the Taj was back in business. The landmark hotel once again opened its doors to welcome guests with the same singular elegance and unmatched warmth as it had been doing for over a century. When it reopened, Ratan said that the ‘venerable old lady’, as he described the flagship property, exhibited the spirit of resilience.

Built in 1903, the Taj stands tall as a testimony to Jamsetji’s defiance of the British for barring Indians from their hotels. It has come to symbolize the spirit of Indian patriotism and nationalism. Over time, it has also grown to become one of the most iconic structures in Mumbai, perhaps the only one that is not owned by the government. It is a landmark of such eminent recognition that the central dome of the hotel serves as an official daytime triangulation point for the Indian Navy.

For Mumbaikars, the Taj holds extra significance as, unlike the other iconic structures in the city, it was built by an Indian to challenge the racist